A fantastic way to use this much maligned, fragrant weed—choose young and tender specimens and wear a double layer of latex gloves to pick them.

nettle soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS

2 tbsp canola oil or olive oil
4 scallions, sliced
3 leeks, coarsely chopped
1lb 7oz (650g) potatoes, washed but not peeled, cut into ¾in (2cm) cubes
sea salt
1 quart (1 liter) vegetable stock
3½oz (100g) young nettles or nettle tips (about ¼ bag full), washed
juice of half a lemon
freshly ground black pepper
plain thick yogurt, to serve

1 Heat the oil in a heavy soup pan over medium heat. Add the scallions, leeks, and potatoes with a little sea salt. Stir, cover, and cook for about 5 minutes, stirring frequently.

2 Add the stock and bring to a boil. Add the nettles, stir, and simmer for 10 minutes, or until the potatoes are soft. Cool briefly, then purée with a hand blender until completely smooth. Taste for seasoning, then squeeze in a little lemon juice and grind in some pepper. Serve each bowl with a dollop of thick yogurt and more pepper.



PICKING NETTLES
Because they grow everywhere, nettles are generally easy to find. When fresh, the stems are firm and the young leaves are green, but ones with wilted or yellowing leaves should be avoided. Cooked nettles lose their sting.